CSIS JAPAN CHAIR

Japan Daily Brief

Sunday, October 25, 2026

1,785 words · 7 min read

RE: US Marine indicted Okinawa · Kim visits China · Imperial succession law · Keen Sword 27 · Takaichi EV push Germany

NIKKEI 225	USD/JPY	BRENT	BOJ RATE
62,693.16	156.81	$111.70	1.00%
▼ -3.43%	▼ -0.63%	▲ +2.67%	

TOP STORIES

ALLIANCE

U.S. Marine indicted in Okinawa robbery-murder case

Prosecutors indicted a *20-year-old* US Marine on suspicion of robbing and murdering a woman in Okinawa Prefecture, allegedly strangling her with a telephone cord in a hotel room in Naha. Asahi Shimbun reporting indicates the suspect returned to base after the incident, changed clothes, and went back out — a sequence that is fueling local anger, with one Koza shopkeeper quoted saying 'nothing has changed.'

THE JAPAN TIMES

POLITICS-DIET

Japan's revised Imperial law reinforcing male-only succession takes effect amid public opposition

Japan's revised Imperial Household Law — which reinforces the male-only line of succession and is described by the Washington Post as unpopular — has taken effect. The revision forecloses a female imperial succession path that opinion polls have consistently shown majority public support for.

WASHINGTON POST · OCT 25

DPRK

N. Korea's Kim visits China via border bridge, meets China's No. 4 Wang

Kim Jong Un entered China via a border bridge and met with Wang, identified by Kyodo as China's fourth-ranked official, in what South Korean media and NHK World both reported as a confirmed visit. The meeting's agenda was not detailed in available reporting, but the crossing marks a notable diplomatic movement by Kim.

KYODO NEWS

ECONOMY-BOJ

Japan PM Takaichi to urge Germany for favorable EV treatment in EU

Prime Minister **Sanae Takaichi** is set to urge Germany for favorable treatment of Japanese electric vehicles within the EU regulatory framework at an upcoming Japan-Germany summit. The approach reflects Tokyo's broader effort to use bilateral diplomacy to shape EU industrial policy affecting Japanese automakers.

NIKKEI ASIA

DEFENSE

Japanese and U.S. Partners Conduct Airfield Damage Repair Training at Keen Sword 27

Japanese and US military partners conducted airfield damage repair training as part of Keen Sword 27, the bilateral exercise series. The training scenario — restoring damaged runways under contested conditions — directly reflects Japan's posture for defending Southwest Islands airfields.

PACOM.MIL

ECONOMY-BOJ

Why 17 is not the magic number in industrial policy

The Financial Times argues that Prime Minister **Sanae Takaichi**'s growth strategy spreads across 17 industrial sectors, a lack of focus that the paper says threatens to hobble the plan's effectiveness. The critique arrives as Takaichi enters her second year and faces Kyodo poll approval below *50 percent* for the first time.

FT

STAT OF THE DAY

7.0

Magnitude of earthquake near Japan's Ogasawara Islands (no tsunami)

A magnitude-7.0 earthquake struck waters near Japan's Ogasawara Islands today; Japan's Meteorological Agency confirmed no tsunami was triggered.

7.0-magnitude quake hits off islands south of Tokyo, no tsunami triggered — The Straits Times

JAPANESE GOVERNMENT

KANTEI/PM · CABINET · MOFA · MOD · METI · MOF · BOJ · DIET · SUNDAY, OCTOBER 25, 2026

PM Watch: No confirmed PM appearance today · 1 day(s) since last confirmed appearance

防衛省 · MINISTRY OF DEFENSE / GROUND SELF-DEFENSE FORCE

GSDF publicly displays new Type-25 surface-to-ship missile at training range

The Japan Ground Self-Defense Force conducted the first public display of the long-range Type-25 surface-to-ship guided missile (25式地対艦誘導弾) at a training range. The unveiling is part of Japan's ongoing Southwest Islands defense buildup under the 2022 National Security Strategy.

→ Asahi ↗

内閣サイバーセキュリティセンター · MINISTRY OF INTERNAL AFFAIRS AND COMMUNICATIONS / DIGITAL AND CYBERSECURITY

GMO Internet requests government 'active cyber defense' after data breach via unauthorized access

Japanese internet conglomerate GMO Internet Group requested the government invoke active cyber defense measures following unauthorized access and information leakage affecting the company. The request tracks with ongoing government deliberations on expanding Japan's active cyber defense legal framework.

→ Nikkei Asia ↗

総務省 · GOVERNMENT / ELECTION ADMINISTRATION

Japan urges social media platforms to curb election misinformation

Japanese authorities called on social media platforms to take steps to suppress misinformation in election contexts. The move follows recent episodes of coordinated disinformation during Japanese electoral cycles.

→ Nikkei Asia ↗

DIET SESSIONS / LDP

HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES / DIET

Opposition demands Prime Minister Takaichi personally defend tax cut bill details

CDP and other opposition representatives formally urged Prime Minister **Sanae Takaichi** to appear before the Diet and explain the food consumption tax cut bill herself, specifically questioning the lack of details about a planned benefit program included in the legislation. The demand escalates pressure on Takaichi as the Diet debate over the bill continues.

FUKUSHIMA PREFECTURE

Fukushima Governor Masao Uchibori wins fourth term, defeating six challengers

Incumbent Governor **Masao Uchibori** secured a fourth consecutive term in the Fukushima gubernatorial election, defeating challengers including a JCP-backed candidate. The result consolidates continuity in the prefecture's ongoing post-Fukushima reconstruction and energy policy.

CONSTITUTIONAL DEMOCRATIC PARTY (CDP)

Former CDP leader Yukio Edano calls for swift 'reunion' of CDP-affiliated forces, opposes party name change

Former CDP leader **Yukio Edano** called for CDP-affiliated groups to reach a swift conclusion on reunification, stating a party name change would be 'rather a negative.' The remarks signal continuing intraparty debate over the opposition's consolidation strategy ahead of the next national election.

HYOGO PREFECTURE

Hyogo prefectural assembly by-election between former deputy governor and LDP-aligned ex-city council member held today

A Hyogo prefectural assembly by-election pitting a former deputy governor against an LDP-aligned former city council member is due for balloting and vote-counting today. The race is a downstream consequence of the political turmoil surrounding Hyogo Governor Motohiko Saito.

● PUBLIC SENTIMENT & APPROVAL POLLING

POLLSTER	APPROVE	DISAPPROVE
ANN · Oct 19, 2026	**47.1%**	**33.3%**
Asahi · Oct 19, 2026	**50%**	**35%**
Kyodo · Oct 19, 2026	**49.1%**	**33%**

FNN · Oct 19, 2026	**62.6%**	**32.3%**
Yomiuri · Oct 19, 2026	**57%**	**30%**
NHK · Oct 14, 2026	**50.8%**	**32%**
JNN · Oct 4, 2026	**63%**	**33.9%**

Discourse: Opposition parties are pressing Takaichi to personally defend the food consumption tax cut bill in Diet committee, as her Kyodo approval rating (49.1%) has dipped below 50 percent for the first time since taking office — with respondents citing 'no alternative' as the main reason to maintain support.

Poll tracker: **Observing Japan approval-rating aggregator →**

BUSINESS & ECONOMY

AUTO · MAINICHI · TOYOTA, HONDA, NISSAN

Japanese automakers accelerate vehicle development timelines to counter Chinese rivals

Japanese automakers are compressing vehicle development cycles to close a competitive gap with Chinese EV manufacturers. No specific timeline figure was given in available reporting, but the effort spans multiple major Japanese marques.

ENERGY · MAINICHI

Japanese marine engine maker unveils world's first hydrogen engine for large commercial vessels, cutting CO2 by 95%

A Japanese marine engine manufacturer developed what it describes as the world's first hydrogen-fueled engine for large commercial vessels, achieving a *95 percent* reduction in CO2 emissions. The engine was unveiled in Osaka.

MANUFACTURING · NIKKEI ASIA · KAMEDA SEIKA

Kameda Seika exits India market, pivots overseas strategy to North America

Japanese snack maker Kameda Seika is withdrawing from the Indian market and redirecting its overseas expansion toward North America. The shift reflects the broader reconfiguration of Japanese consumer-goods companies' international footprints.

FINANCE · NIKKEI ASIA · TOKIO MARINE HOLDINGS

Tokio Marine becomes first Japanese non-life insurer to offer coverage for AI-enabled robots

Tokio Marine Holdings introduced insurance products covering AI-enabled robots, becoming the first Japanese non-life insurer to enter this segment. The product addresses liability and operational risks from autonomous robotic systems.

MANUFACTURING · THE JAPAN TIMES · ASAHI, KIRIN, SUNTORY, SAPPORO

Japan FTC investigates possible shipping-price cartel among major brewers after 2023 tax cut

The Japan Fair Trade Commission is investigating a suspected cartel involving Asahi, Kirin, Suntory, and Sapporo over shipping prices, with the probe focusing on whether the companies held beer prices steady following the 2023 alcohol tax cut. The case raises competition-law questions for Japan's major beverage groups.

TECH · NIKKEI ASIA

Japanese car-sharing operator to pay users $19 each following data breach

A Japanese car-sharing operator announced it will offer *$19* per user as compensation following a data breach. The case adds to a string of cybersecurity incidents at Japanese mobility and logistics firms.

REGIONAL PRESSURE WATCH

Low — 3 items (Japanese government: 1, adversary signal: 2)

CHINA

No new China Coast Guard or PLA activity near the Senkakus is reported in today's Tier 1 or Tier 4 data. China's sustained rare-earth export-control pressure on Japan — framed by Beijing as a response to Japanese 'remilitarization' — continues as the active economic-coercion vector from the prior week, with no new announcement in today's feed.

NORTH KOREA

Kim Jong Un entered China via a border bridge and met with Wang, China's fourth-ranked official, per Kyodo and South Korean media confirmed by NHK World. North Korea's Kim separately issued calls for a 'military revolution' to strengthen army units, per GMA Network, maintaining sustained militarist rhetoric.

RUSSIA

Russia's FSB detention of Hokkaido Shimbun reporter Yuki Imai on espionage charges continues as confirmed by Panay News today, with Russia still denying consular access to Japan.

Senkaku / ECS: No new CCG intrusion, patrol-day record, or PLA activity near the Senkakus is reported in today's data; the sustained patrol pattern from prior weeks continues as baseline.

Bottom line: Kim Jong Un's confirmed entry into China and meeting with Wang is the primary regional signal today; the Russia-Imai detention and North Korean 'military revolution' rhetoric continue without new escalation. Watch for readout on the Kim-Wang meeting agenda.

U.S.-JAPAN RELATIONS

ALLIANCE · INDOPACOM

Japan, Philippines and US conduct trilateral Maritime Cooperative Activity

Japanese, Philippine, and US forces conducted a multilateral Maritime Cooperative Activity, per INDOPACOM. The exercise extends the pattern of trilateral maritime coordination in the South and East China Sea approaches.

INDO-PACIFIC PARTNERS

PACIFIC ISLANDS · NIKKEI ASIA

Japan and Micronesia affirm cooperation on free and open Indo-Pacific

Japan and Micronesia affirmed bilateral cooperation on a free and open Indo-Pacific framework, reinforcing Tokyo's Pacific Islands engagement at a moment when major powers compete for influence in the region.

SOUTHEAST ASIA · NHK

Japan-led geothermal project advances in Tajikistan

A Japan-led geothermal development project is underway in Tajikistan, extending Tokyo's energy and infrastructure engagement into Central Asia as part of its connectivity diplomacy.

SOCIAL STATEMENTS

ST

Sanae Takaichi
Prime Minister of Japan · nippon.com · Oct 2026

“No alternative”

Analyst: Cited by respondents in the Kyodo poll as the primary reason for continuing to support the Takaichi Cabinet despite approval falling below 50 percent for the first time.

Source →

UPCOMING

Oct 25

Hyogo prefectural assembly by-election ballot and count — today

Voting and counting for the Hyogo prefectural assembly by-election takes place today, featuring a former deputy governor against an LDP-affiliated former city council member.

Oct 26

Peru president's visit to Japan — arrangements underway

NHK reports arrangements are underway for Peru's president to visit Japan; the exact date was not specified in available sources but imminent diplomatic preparations are confirmed.

Oct 27

Bangladesh PM Tarique Rahman — 4-day official visit to Japan

Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman has begun a 4-day official visit to Japan; multiple MoUs on economic cooperation are under discussion, with Tokyo eyeing fresh investment momentum.

Nov 1

Bank of Japan Monetary Policy Meeting — next scheduled decision window (estimate)

Markets are watching for the BOJ's next policy rate decision; the Nikkei recovered to the 62,000 level after a -3.43% session, with AI earnings and central bank events flagged as key near-term catalysts.

Nov 7

Japan-Germany summit — Takaichi to press EV issue

Prime Minister Takaichi is expected to raise Japan's request for favorable EU treatment of Japanese electric vehicles at an upcoming Japan-Germany bilateral summit; the exact date was not specified in available sources but Nikkei Asia describes it as forthcoming.

CSIS Japan Chair

JAPAN DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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generated 7:05 AM ET

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